INTRODUCTION

§ 1. OLD English is a member of the West Germanic division of the Germanic (Teutonic) branch of the Indo-Germanic family of languages. This great family of languages is usually divided into eight branches :—

I. **Aryan,** consisting of: (1) The Indian group, including the language of the Vedas, classical Sanskrit, and the Prākrit dialects. (2) The Iranian group, including (*a*) West Iranian (Old Persian, the language of the Persian cuneiform inscriptions, dating from about 520–350 B.C.); (*b*) East Iranian (Avesta—sometimes called Zend-Avesta, Zend, and Old Bactrian—the language of the Avesta, the sacred books of the Zoroastrians).

II. **Armenian,** the oldest monuments of which belong to the fifth century A.D.

III. Greek, with its numerous dialects.

IV. **Albanian,** the language of ancient Illyria. The oldest monuments belong to the seventeenth century.

V. **Italic,** consisting of Latin and the Umbrian-Samnitic dialects. From the popular form of Latin are descended the Romance languages: Portuguese, Spanish, Catalanian, Provençal, French, Italian, Raetoromanic, Roumanian or Wallachian.

VI. **Keltic,** consisting of: (1) Gaulish (known to us by Keltic names and words quoted by Latin and Greek authors, and inscriptions on coins; (2) Britannic, including Cymric or Welsh, Cornish, and Bas Breton or Armorican (the oldest records of Cymric and Bas Breton date back to the eighth or ninth century); (3) Gaelic, including Irish-

Gaelic, Scotch-Gaelic, and Manx. The oldest monuments are the old Gaelic ogam inscriptions which probably date as far back as about 500 A.D.

VII. **Baltic-Slavonic,** consisting of: (1) The Baltic division, embracing (*a*) Old Prussian, which became extinct in the seventeenth century, (*b*) Lithuanian, (*c*) Lettic (the oldest records of Lithuanian and Lettic belong to the sixteenth century); (2) the Slavonic division, embracing: (*a*) the South-Eastern group, including Russian (Great Russian, White Russian, and Little Russian), Bulgarian, and Illyrian (Servian, Croatian, Slovenian); (*b*) the Western group, including Czech (Bohemian), Sorabian (Wendish), Polish and Polabian.

VIII. **Germanic,** consisting of:—

(1) **Gothic.** Almost the only source of our knowledge of the Gothic language is the fragments of the biblical translation made in the fourth century by Ulfilas, the Bishop of the West Goths.

(2) **Old Norse** (Scandinavian), which is sub-divided into two groups: (*a*) East Norse, including Swedish, Gutnish, and Danish; (*b*) West Norse, including Norwegian, and Icelandic.

The oldest records of this branch are the runic inscriptions, some of which date as far back as the third or fourth century.

(3) **West Germanic,** which is composed of:—

(*a*) High German, the oldest monuments of which belong to about the middle of the eighth century.

(*b*) Low Franconian, called Old Low Franconian or Old Dutch until about 1200.

(*c*) Low German, with records dating back to the ninth century. Up to about 1200 it is generally called Old Saxon.

(*d*) Frisian, the oldest records of which belong to the fourteenth century.

(*e*) English, the oldest records of which belong to about the end of the seventh century.

NOTE.—1. A few of the chief characteristics of the Germanic languages as compared with the other branches of the Indo-Germanic languages are: the first sound-shifting or Grimm's law (§§ **229–34**); Verner's law (§ **238**); the development of the so-called weak declension of adjectives (§ **421**); the development of the preterite of weak verbs (§ **520**); the use of the old perfect as a preterite (§ **481**).

2. The most characteristic differences between Gothic and Old Norse on the one hand, and of West Germanic on the other, are: the West Germanic gemination of consonants (§§ **254–6**); the loss of final **z** which arose from Indo-Germanic **s** by Verner's law (§ **252**); the West Germanic development of prim. Germanic **ww** (§ **90**), **jj** (§ **275**); the form of the second pers. sing. pret. indicative of strong verbs (§ **481**). Gothic and Old Norse preserved the old perfect ending, as Goth. Old Norse **namt**, *thou tookest*, but OE. **nōme**, OS. OHG. **nāmi**. In the West Germanic languages the **-t** was only preserved in the preterite-present verbs, as OE. **wāst**, OS. **wēst**, OHG. **weist**, *thou knowest*.

3. The most characteristic difference between High German and the other Germanic languages is: the High German sound-shifting (§ **230**).

§ **2**. The division of a language into fixed periods must of necessity be more or less arbitrary. What are given as the characteristics of one period have generally had their beginnings in the previous period, and it is impossible to say with perfect accuracy when one period begins and another ends. For practical purposes Old English may be conveniently divided into two periods: early OE. from about 700 to 900; and late OE. from 900–1100.

§ **3**. The oldest records of OE. exhibit clearly defined dialectal peculiarities which have been treated in some detail in the phonology, so that the student can easily collect together for himself the chief characteristics of each dialect. In this grammar early West Saxon is taken

as the standard for OE., and is treated in greater detail than the other dialects. In using OE. poetry for grammatical purposes the student should remember that it was for the most part originally written in the Anglian dialect, but that it has come down to us chiefly in late West Saxon copies which contain many Anglian forms. OE. is usually divided into four dialects: (*a*) Northumbrian, embracing the district between the Firth of Forth and the Humber. (*b*) Mercian, between the Humber and the Thames. (*c*) West Saxon, south of the Thames, except Kent and Surrey. (*d*) Kentish, embracing Kent and Surrey. Northumbrian and Mercian are often classed together and called Anglian.

NOTE.—A detailed comparison of late OE. phonology with that of the Modern dialects would doubtless show that the dialects of Sussex and East Anglia were closely related to the dialect of Kent in the OE. period. This is not the place for such a comparison, so one example must suffice here. The change of ȳ to ē (§ **132**, Note) in late OE. is always regarded as a special Kentish peculiarity, but the same sound change must also have taken place in Sussex and East Anglia, where OE. ȳ has regularly become ī (through the older stage ē) in the Modern dialects, as **līs** (OE. **lȳs**), *lice*; **mīs** (OE. **mȳs**), *mice*; whereas had ȳ simply been unrounded to ī in the late OE. period of these dialects, the Modern forms would have been ***lois** and ***mois**.